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Context of the Present form of Non-Alignment —

i) Change in the world Order — from bipolar to Unipolar & from Unipolar to Multi-polar.

Why there was a need to redefine? —

B/c Non-Alignment as a Concept originated during Cold war. Height of bipolarity. (2 Superpowers).

In this situation, it was not advisable that India joins with any of the Superpower. Joining one superpower would have invited the wrath of other.

At the same time, India's Geography, its political system, the model of Economy, its diversity would not have allowed joining a particular block.

From Nehru's PoV, Non-Alignment was the only option to generate consensus (domestic Consensus).

* Non-Alignment in the age of Unipolarity —

When there is a single Super power, there is no point to balancing & hence India preferred the mode of Strategic Partnership with USA.

This phrase represent a qualitative change in India's relations with USA, the Single Super Power.

B/c throughout Cold war they were estranged Democracies.

Hence, South block was known for Reflexive Anti-Americanism.

The situation of Unipolarity compelled the readjustment in the Posture.

* Non-Alignment in Present Time (Non-Alignment 2.0) :-

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It is a well established fact that Unipolarity is inherently unstable. Hence, India was cautious in not giving the impressions that it treats U.S. as its ally.

Hence, on various international issues we kept our Independent position. India avoided "Band wagoning" with USA.

In the Present age when world has become too much interdependent, staying away from any of the power, Regional arrangement or block is not an option. Hence, Non-Alignment became multiple alignment.

If India has been in QUAD, it has also been in SCO. If India is engaging with EU for FTA, it is also engaging with Eurasian Economic Union (EEU).

Today, India is confident about its position, while Strengthening Defence Partnership with Russia, we have also initiated Dialogue with NATO.

Multiple alignment allows India to avoid Political bargaining, a room to manoeuvrability & to take decisions w/o are in the best interest of the Country.

Even major powers have acknowledged India's independent approach. Neither US nor Russia compels anymore to be a camp follower.

India has also gained leadership among the countries of 3rd world by maintaining its Principle Stand. Non-Alignment has become part and Parck of India's identity.

Why 2nd Change is happening ? -

* Change of Guards in South block -

From 1990s onwards there has been an ideological shift in India's Political establishment -

i) There was a beginning of Congress led Govt. w/c was not headed by Gandhi family.

Though Indira Gandhi itself didn't stick to Nehruvian legacy and moved towards more realistic posture, Non-Gandhi Prime Ministers of Congress had little illusions with Nehruvian Legacy.

ii) Since BJP came to power, they had least illusion with Non-Alignment.

a) When Vajpayee was P.M. and Brajesh Mishra was his principal Secretary & later on NSA, he started using the term Strategic Autonomy rather than Non-Alignment.

Though, the language got changed yet the essence continued.

b) Under P.M. Modi, we see two Phases -

i) Pre-Covid

ii) Pre-Ukraine war Phase -

i) P.M. Modi became the 1st Indian P.M who didn't attend NAM summit.

ii) He was not apologetic in making the statement in context of India-US relation that "We have ~~to~~ overcome the hesitation of the ~~Museum~~ Past".

Similarly, S. Jayshankar has been a vehement critic of Non-Alignment.

However, during Covid Modi realised the relevance of NAM, organised a virtual summit where he held that we require "New Template for Globalisation".

Since, war in Ukraine we hear time and again India's Foreign Minister asserting India's Non-Aligned Status, India's Strategic Autonomy.

This shows that Non-Alignment will continue to remain the archetypic idea in the South block, till we do not invent any thing, w/c can replace the signature concept.

With the change in the governance, terminologies may change but substantiated will endure b/c Foreign Policies are based on long-term interest driven by History, Geography, Culture, Commerce.

• watch
G. D. Goenka
lecture. ~~watch~~

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* Look - East Policy :-

- It is India's major Foreign Policy initiative after the end of Cold War. The Credit to initiate the Policy goes to Narasimha Rao in 1991.

However, a/c to Prof. S.D. Muni :- "Look East Policy is much old than what we think."

He talks about Four phases of Evolution in Look East.

- i) In Ancient times - when there was expansion of India's Culture and tradition to Indo-China region, under Cholas and other, kings and trading Communities.
- ii) Medieval Times - The focus shifted from maritime domain and from South East to the Eurasian Region & specially Central Asia.
- iii) 3rd Phase - During Colonial times, Britishers integrated Regions to some extent for long time - Myanmar was being ruled by British Indian administration.

During 2nd World War we realised the importance of the Region for India's Security. There was a fear of Japanese aggression from North-East.

- iv) 4th Phase :- Post Independence - Nehru revived Asian solidarity by organising Asian relations Conference in March 1946 & later on Asian Conference, w/c was organised in Bandung in ~~1954~~ / 1955.

However, b/c the region became the Hotspot of the Geo-Political rivalry during Cold war (Vietnam War), that the integration could not be furthered / Programmed.

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At the same time, India was compelled to look in the Continental direction and the entire focus was shifted towards China and Pakistan.

South East Asia became highly polarised region.

In 1967, ASEAN was formed as Pro-US block.

Hence, India could not develop engagement with these countries.

B/c Russia was ally of Vietnam, India was also close to Vietnam.

As India's Economy was also closed, there was nothing much to engage with the Region.

* Post Cold - War Scenario !

Following factors were responsible for India's initiative of look East. :-

- i) Disintegration of USSR and therefore India needed new friends.
- ii) New Economic Policy, India needed to trade with the outside world and had to invite Foreign Investment.

South East Asia was Emerging as the dynamic Economic Region.

- iii) India's troubled neighbourhood.

Neither India's Political Relations with the neighbours were good nor there was scope for Economic Engagement.

South - Asian Economies are not Complementary rather Supplementary.

At the same time, South Asian Economies have been Protectionist Economy.

Hence, India had to look towards extended neighbourhood.

* Evolution of Look East Policy :-

Look East has been a highly dynamic initiative.

i) Phase 1 - "During 1990s" - It was Primarily an Economic ~~set~~ initiative with focus on South East Asia. It means improving relations with Asean Countries (ASEAN Centrality).

ii) Phase 2nd - In 21st Century (During Vaipayee) -

There was expansion in the scope and ambition. Besides ASEAN, the idea was to strengthen the relationship with Japan South Korea, the Island nations of Pacific (Fiji).

It also graduated from major Economic initiative to Strategic initiative.

Defence Co-operation in terms of training, Capacity building, Naval Exercises (MILAN Exercises) started.

During Vaipayee, Policy also developed Domestic dimension. It means Look East through North-East.

Integrating India's Economically Backward Region with limited Connectivity, with mainland to Asia's vibrant Economies (Thailand, Singapore), by developing Connectivity.

Myanmar became the Gateway for the New Initiative.

*iii) Present Phase :-

Modi Year -

2014 - "12th ASEAN - INDIA Summit" at Naypitaw
Myanmar.

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P.M. Modi launched Act East Policy. The then Foreign Minister Sushma Swaraj described Act East with 3Cs :-

Culture

Commerce

Connectivity

• Background of Act East :-

From the very beginning, Look East Policy had strategic overtones. It means it was focused on China. As China was expanding its footprints in India's neighbourhood, it was essential for India to strengthen its presence in Chinese neighbourhood.

One of the objective ~~was~~ of Look East Policy was to ensure the Peaceful Rise.

In Context of the common objective of ensuring that China's rise remain peaceful, US started looking at India as a balancer.

Hence, there has been a Push-Factor by USA compelling India to take - "Strategic View of this Critical Geography" "

Former US Secretary of State, Hillary Clinton, reflecting the dissatisfaction with the sluggishness of India's Engagement, appealed that India should not just look East, it should Act East.

Hence, when there was a change of Guards in South block, India took the bold step.

* Comparison b/w the Policy of Congress & B.J.P w.r.t to Asia - Pacific :-

Whether it was Vajpayee Govt. (Coalition Govt.) or Manmohan Singh Govt. (Nehruvian Approach), they didn't want to take any such step w/c alienates China.

They Preferred Engagement over containment.

However, P.M. Modi, who is known for his bold decisions, did not hesitate in "Stepping Up the Ante."

Thus, India aimed at Greater integration with the Region Strengthening Security Partnership.

* Initiative by Modi Govt. :-

i) Stepping Up the relations with the neighbouring Countries of China. —

a) Mongolia — Strategic Partnership.

b) Special Strategic Partnerships with Japan & South Korea.

c) Strategic Partnership with Australia.

d) Traditionally, India had closed relations with Singapore, Vietnam, Thailand, present govt. Upgrade relations with Philippines, Cambodia, Indonesia.

India has overcome the hesitation of the past, India became the member of QUAD.

e) GoI has initiated special initiatives like - **SAGAR, Indo-Pacific Indian Ocean Initiative.**

* Another very Strategic Initiative of Present Govt. is Act Far East. Policy. It means integrating with Russia's Far East with the objective to dilute Russia's opposition to Indo-Pacific and to establish India's legitimate interest in South China Sea.

f) Revitalisation of BIMSTEC.

g) Strengthening Co-operation in Maritime Domain.

Q) Whether Act East Represent Continuity or Change with look East. ? -

In fact, it is more of a continuity than Change.

The elemental Features include -

i) Development of India's North-East.

ii) Upgrading Existing Partnership.

iii) Building New Partnerships.

iv) Focus on Maritime Domain.

Presently, Act East Policy has ~~been~~ become a component of India's wider Geo-Political Construct i.e. Free and Open Indo-Pacific.

Q) What Strategies GoI had adopted in the Region ? -

i) Strengthening Economic Partnership - In the year 2010, ASEAN became the 1st and so far the only Regional Organisation with w/c we have FTA in Goods. It has been a highly ambitious FTA w/c has liberalised the tariffs on more than 90% of the Goods traded. Out of w/c there is a elimination of Duties on almost 77% of the total Goods traded.

There has been a significant increase in the trade b/w India and ASEAN Countries. At present, the trade in Goods with ASEAN has reached to **\$ 110 bn (2020-21)**. Whereas ASEAN's trade with China for the same is **\$ 274.50 bn**.

FTA in Goods is highly favourable to ASEAN Countries.

Asean Countries have been reluctant to negotiate FTA in services w/c would have brought the balance in the trade.

In 2015, there was FTA in services and Investment.

However, all Countries are not part of Agreement in services. Ex - Philippines - b/c we are competitors in IT Services.

What is the Present Status ? -

GoI had suggested to start the negotiations to update the FTA in both Goods and Services.

FDI from ASEAN to India b/w 2000 to 2018 has been \$ 68.91 bn & from India to ASEAN ~~from~~ \$ 38.67 bn.

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The basic problem is that we are getting almost 90% of the investment only from Singapore.

Hence, there is a need to diversify the sources and destinations both.

As of now, India has opted to stay out of RCEP.

Why ? -

India already has FTA in Goods & Services and investment with ASEAN Countries.

India has CEPA with Japan & South-Korea.

India has recently entered into FTA with Australia.

Thus, Primarily it is China Factor w/c is prohibiting India to join the Agreement. India prefers bilateral deals to avoid China.

Besides trade & Commerce, India has development Partnership with LDCs (Least Developing Countries) of ASEAN Region (CLMV Countries).

India has estd. 3 Funds -

- i) ASEAN-India Cooperation Fund - with the initial Capital of \$ 50 mn.
- ii) ASEAN-India Sci & Tech Development Fund - with initial Capital of \$ 1mn w/c is upgraded in 2022 to \$ 5mn.
- iii) ASEAN-India Green Fund - with initial Capital of \$ 5 mn for sustainable development.

* Security Co-operation —

India has been an active Participant of all Security Initiatives in the Region led by ASEAN as well as other Countries (QUAD).

Since, 2010, India participates in ASEAN Defence Ministers meet⁺ (ADMM⁺).

Since 1996, we are Participating in the Security Platform led by ASEAN Countries known as ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF). The only Regional Forum on Security where North and South Korea have dialogue. Till India - Pak joined SCO, the only Security Platform for dialogue in Asia b/w India - Pak.